

Artificial Intelligence (AI) Usage Policy

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Overview

AI tools are a reality of modern software and data work. This course **allows** the use of AI assistants – but with boundaries that reflect real-world professional standards. The rules below are not arbitrary academic restrictions; they mirror the policies you will encounter at virtually every company you work for.

Understanding *why* these rules exist is as important as following them.

What You CAN Do

Allowed	Examples
Use AI to understand concepts	"Explain what a foreign key is"
Use AI to write or debug SQL	"Write a query that finds customers with no invoices"
Use AI to check your reasoning	"Does this sorting algorithm look correct?"
Use AI as a study tool	Generate practice problems, ask for explanations
Use AI to improve your writing	Proofread a report section you drafted yourself
Use AI to explore ideas	"What are the trade-offs between a Python Flask and a .NET backend?"
Use AI to generate code	UI code, scripts, functions, classes, helper utilities, etc. – for your project

AI is a tool, like a calculator or a search engine. Using it to learn faster and work smarter is encouraged. If AI writes your Python code, JS code, or SQL query, or helps you build your project UI, that is fine – the industry works this way, and so does this course.

What You CANNOT Do

Prohibited	Why
Upload assignment documents, project descriptions, or exam questions to any public AI system	See explanation below – this is the absolute rule
Use AI during oral exams / video recordings	The entire point is demonstrating <i>your</i> understanding out loud

The Core Rule – Why You Cannot Upload Course Documents

You may not upload any course assignment, project description, exam question, or proprietary document to a public AI service such as ChatGPT, Google Gemini, Microsoft Copilot (consumer), Claude.ai, or any similar publicly hosted AI platform.

This is not a rule made up for the classroom. Here is the real-world context:

In the Industry: NDAs and Confidentiality

When you work at a company, you will sign a **Non-Disclosure Agreement (NDA)**. This legally binds you to keep the company's internal information – source code, business logic, client data, product plans, internal documents – confidential.

If you take a confidential document and upload it to ChatGPT, you have just transmitted your employer's proprietary information to a third-party server operated by a private company, **outside your employer's control**. That is a breach of the NDA. People have been fired for this. Even if they claim not to use it for model training, they will certainly save it. You cannot have documents under NDA saved on a 3rd party server that's not under your control.

In the Industry: Shadow AI Policy

Most organizations have an **AI usage policy** (sometimes called a **Shadow AI policy**) that explicitly prohibits employees from using unauthorized, consumer-grade AI tools with company data. These policies exist because:

- Data uploaded to consumer AI services may be used to train future models
- There is no guarantee of confidentiality, deletion, or data sovereignty
- The company has no visibility into what was shared or what came back

Major incidents have already occurred – Samsung engineers leaked chip designs by pasting internal code into ChatGPT. That incident led to Samsung banning AI tools company-wide temporarily, and is now a textbook example in enterprise security training.

In This Course

The course materials — assignment rubrics, project descriptions, exam questions — are the intellectual property of the instructor and the University of Houston. Uploading them to a public AI system:

1. Violates UH's academic integrity policies
2. Removes the assessment value of the assignment (if everyone feeds the prompt to AI, the assignment becomes meaningless)
3. **Most importantly:** it is a habit that will get you fired in the real world

By following this rule in class, you are building the professional instinct that protects both you and your employer.

Approved AI Workflow

If you want to use AI effectively **without** violating this policy, here is the correct approach:

Instead of uploading the assignment:

 *[paste full project description PDF into ChatGPT]"Do this for me."*

Describe the problem yourself in your own words:

 "I have a table with these columns: student_id, student_name, course_id, course_name, grade. The PK is (student_id, course_id). Help me find any partial dependencies."

 "I have to write a python program that connects to a mySQL database and retrieves information about xyw. I also need a command-line menu."

 DIRECT access to course documents is only allowed within a protected AI environment, such as a business/pro account for various AI platforms, or the University-provided access to Gemini and/or NotebookLM. This must be clearly stated in the AI usage declaration.

The difference: you are directing AI as a tool, not handing it proprietary documents. The course material stays off public servers.

Disclosure — Required AI Use File

If you use AI for any part of a submitted assignment, you **must** submit a separate disclosure file alongside your submission.

File requirements

- **File name:** `ai_use.txt` or `ai_use.md`

- **Submit with every assignment** where AI was used — as a separate file on the same Canvas submission
- If you did not use AI at all, you do not need to submit this file

What the file must contain

A vague statement is not acceptable. The file must document, for every instance of AI use:

1. **What tool was used** — e.g., ChatGPT, GitHub Copilot, Claude, Gemini (enterprise/school version), Grok, etc.
2. **What it was used for** — e.g., "Make an API call to my backend and load the data into a Javascript array, displayed on the home screen.", "Explain the difference between LEFT JOIN and INNER JOIN", "Proof-read the written analysis section"
3. **The prompt(s) you used** — paste the actual prompt(s) you sent to the AI
4. **What you kept vs. what you changed** — e.g., "Used the generated JS code as a starting point and added a call to save the changes."

A single sentence like "AI was used" is not sufficient and will be treated as non-disclosure.

Regardless of the AI tool, the output must always be double checked for correctness. Simply copy-pasting AI output as your submission without verifying it is never allowed.

Consequence of non-disclosure

If no `ai_use` file is submitted, it will be assumed that **no AI was used for that assignment**.

If it is later determined that AI was used and no disclosure file was submitted, the matter will be referred to the University of Houston **Office of Academic Integrity** as an academic dishonesty case. This is not a warning — it is the outcome.

Disclosure is not a penalty. The disclosure file will not affect your grade. It is a professional transparency requirement — the same kind of documentation that responsible teams maintain when using AI-assisted tooling in production environments.

Summary

Rule	Reason
✓ AI for learning, studying, exploring	Good professional skill
✓ AI to write SQL queries or code	Fine — the industry works this way

Rule	Reason
✓ AI for drafting, proofreading, generating	Fine – submit <code>ai_use.txt</code> with full disclosure
✗ Upload assignment/project/exam docs to public AI	NDA + Shadow AI policy violation – absolute no-go
✗ AI during oral exams or homework recordings	Defeats the entire purpose

The goal is not to prevent you from using AI. The goal is to make sure you understand what you're doing – and that you build the professional habits that will protect your career.

Questions about this policy? Contact me via MS Teams or email.